



Portrait Guide #016

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–12 hours Subject Young Female Tennis player

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is doing, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils - Set of 24, Portrait Colors

— the roles this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step names a number you don't have, match the role.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. No solvent — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



30% Warm Grey

PC1052

Light value base, monochromatic foundation to preserve paper tooth and establish form range without cool undertone



Henna

PC1031

Measured mid-value red-orange skin midtone; chromatic anchor for optical mixing and warm unified base



Burnt Ochre

PC943

Measured mid-warm undertone for skin planes; adds depth and optical warmth without darkening



Chestnut

PC1081

Measured dark red-orange for shadow planes, hair roots, and core shadow anchoring; warm dark maintaining luminosity



Dark Umber

PC947

Measured very dark warm shadow for deepest cores (eye socket, jaw recess, under-chin); rich brown-black



Violet

PC932

Chromatic cool shadow and undertone; complementary to warm skin; glazed into core shadows to intensify without grey



Lavender

PC934

Cool mid-value glaze for shadow zones; luminous cool undertone that preserves form and prevents ashy appearance



Clay Rose

PC1017

Warm mid-pink undertone for cheek and jaw transitions; bridges lit and shadow planes with warmth



Peach

PC939

Warm glow for subsurface scattering (cheeks, nose, ears); layered for luminous warmth and transition softness



Light Peach

PC927

Very light warm for highlights, peak light points, and luminous mid-light zones; specular accent



Sienna Brown

PC945

Warm mid-tone for hair; builds curly warmth and luminosity in mid-lit clumps; optical mixing with darker roots



True Blue

PC903

Iris base color; layered in radial strokes from pupil outward to create iris depth and luminosity



Sky Blue Light

PC1086

Sclera base (never pure white); light blue-grey for eye whites with naturalistic undertone



Dioxazine Purple Hue

PC132

Measured dark violet for purple headband; true measured colour from reference, not blue



Neon Yellow

PC1035

Bright saturated yellow for neon tanktop base; artist ground truth saturation; mixed with green for neon yellow-green



Light Green

PC920

Measured light green for tanktop light zones and garment highlights; optical mixing with Neon Yellow for neon yellow-green



Carmine Red

PC926

Cool red for upper lip; darker, cooler than lower lip; sits in more shadow



Blush Pink

PC928

Warm pink for lower lip; lighter and warmer than upper lip; catches light and shows subsurface warmth



Black

PC935

Measured near-black for pupils, deepest darks, and final dark re-establishment after burnish



Cream

PC914

Light blending pencil for burnishing; melt layers without darkening; essential for final painted finish

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Warm, frontal to slightly front-left key light; soft diffuse quality suggesting indoor or overcast outdoor lighting

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks where light strikes directly; warm golden-peach glints

LIGHT AREA

Upper face (forehead, bridge of nose, outer cheekbones); bright midtone in lit planes

MIDTONE

Face center (upper cheeks, nose sides); warm mid-value transitions between lit and shadow

SHADOW

Away-side plane (shadow-facing cheek, temple, jaw-line); warm mid-value recess, not dark hollow; soft self-shadow under jaw and chin

CAST SHADOW

Upper eyelid cast shadow over iris (creates depth); subtle shadow under the lower lip and chin

Edge quality notes

Soft, diffuse light creates gentle terminators with gradual transitions; hardest edges at upper eyelid and lash line (highest form contrast); soft edges on jaw, hair, garment allowing integration with background

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Step 1: Value Map Foundation

Entire face (forehead, cheeks, nose, chin, under-eye, upper eyelids)

Light circular strokes in all directions, following facial contours gently; even pressure and coverage

Light pressure

- Colored pencil is non-liftable, so establishing a light, warm-neutral base preserves the paper tooth for all layers to come and prevents a dark, cool base from deadening the warm skin tone. A 30–50% mid-value starting plane allows for both deepening shadows and lifting to bright highlights.
- Apply PC1052 30% Warm Grey in light circular strokes at low pressure, aiming for even coverage across the entire face. The tone should feel like a mid-grey whisper — so light you can still see the paper texture clearly.
- Preserve the paper tooth completely — this pass is NOT the form, it is the foundation. A student habit is to 'fill' this with darker strokes; resist. Stay so light you can see the paper tooth still: the next 10+ layers depend on it being preserved.
- Pressure should remain light (2–3 psi equivalent) throughout; the pencil glides without resistance and never scrubs or fills.

COLORS  PC1052 30% Warm Grey

↔ If PC1052 feels too grey, layer a second pass of PC1052 in the same light strokes rather than switching pencils—this preserves the warm undertone

STOP WHEN

Entire face covered in soft, even mid-value wash · Pencil glides without resistance; paper tooth clearly visible

✦ This layer succeeds when it feels almost too light. You are building a foundation, not rendering form. The next 10+ layers depend on the tooth being preserved, and heavy pressure here crushes it permanently.

02 Step 2: Skin Midtone & Undertone Build (Merged: two passes)

Litplanesofface(forehead,cheekbones,nosebridge,chin)—prioritizing front-facing zones

Light circular strokes following facial contours; entire zone before local deepening; overlay glaze passes

Light to Light-Medium pressure

- Optical mixing requires thin, chromatic layers built across the whole zone before local deepening, so the eye fuses distinct hues (red, yellow, violet) into luminous skin rather than one flat 'skin-colour.' Building unification first prevents patchiness and ensures all layers sit on the same tonal foundation.
- First pass: Establish the measured warm hue across the lit planes using PC1031 Henna as the chromatic anchor (measured #8f4d2f mid red-orange). Apply light circular strokes, following the form contour (forehead apex, cheekbone slopes, nose planes). Overlay lightly with PC943 Burnt Ochre for undertone warmth and depth anchoring. Do not deepen yet — preserve tooth and coverage across the WHOLE zone before any local deepening.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Glaze PC1017 Clay Rose in the transition zones (cheeks, temples, sides of nose, under the chin) to add warmth and integrate the planes. Light pressure, circular strokes, blending where the glaze meets the base. This step unifies the face and prevents the zones from appearing isolated.
- Complete unification across the whole lit zone before moving to shadows. Skin built area-by-area comes out patchy; skin built zone-by-zone and then deepened locally reads unified and luminous.

COLORS

 PC1031 Henna

 PC943 Burnt Ochre

 PC1017 Clay Rose

↔ If PC943 Burnt Ochre feels too dark, layer PC1017 Clay Rose instead to build warmth with less value shift

STOP WHEN

Entire lit plane covered in warm red-orange with visible undertone depth · Strokes glide smoothly without dragging pigment; tooth still visible

✦ If you see an air-gapped patchwork instead of a unified warm plane, you are working too locally. Back up: complete each pass across the WHOLE zone, then deepen locally in the next pass. Unification is an ongoing method, not a closing glaze.

03 Step 3: Shadow Planes & Chromatic Dark (Merged: three passes)

Away-sideplane (shadow-facing cheek, temple, jaw-line shadow, under-chin plane), orbital shadow zone

Directional strokes following form slope; layering warm base with cool complement glaze; sparse dark anchor placement

Light-Medium pressure

- The away-side plane must remain a MID-value WARM plane with one crisp core-shadow edge where the form turns, not a dark blur or ashy hollow. Warm shadow preserves luminosity and form; chromatic shadow (cooler but still warm) prevents a dead, grey appearance and maintains the turn of the head.
- First pass: Establish the away-side as a distinct WARM midplane using PC1081 Chestnut, keeping value at ~40–50% (not dark yet). Directional strokes following the form slope (from temple down the cheek-plane, along the jaw). The core-shadow edge (where cheekbone turns) stays ONE crisp line — not soft, not blurred. This plane should read as a turned form, not a hollow.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Glaze PC932 Violet into the core-shadow edge and deepest shadow recesses (eye socket, jaw-line core, under the chin recess). Light pressure, directional strokes along the form contour. This cool undertone is NOT grey or ashy — it's a luminous complementary layer that intensifies the warm planes around it. The violet stays at medium saturation, not a thick sludge.
- Third pass: Place PC947 Dark Umber in the deepest shadow cores only (the eye socket, jaw-line recess beneath the chin, orbit cast shadow). This anchors value but stays warm-toned. Sparse, directional strokes; do not fill the entire shadow zone.
- Shadows stay WARM, never grey. Glaze olive, sienna, or oxidized warmth into shadow masses; neutral grey or ashy darks kill luminosity — a dead-grey shadow reads as absence of light, not a turned form. This outranks any instinct to cool a shadow down.

COLORS



PC1081 Chestnut



PC932 Violet



PC947 Dark Umber

↔ PC932 Violet may be replaced with PC934 Lavender for a lighter, softer cool undertone if the reference shows a more delicate shadow

STOP WHEN

Shadow plane reads as a turned form with one crisp edge, away-side still warm and mid-value · Strokes follow form direction without dragging; violet glaze is visible but not opaque

★ The most common failure: making the shadow side too dark, too cool, or too flat. Match the reference's actual contrast — soft frontal light caps shadows at MID-value. Keep the warm undertone visible: you should still see the form turn, not vanish into black.

04 Step 4: Eyes – Iris, Sclera & Lash Line

Both eyes, starting with pupil/cast shadow, iris, sclera, upper lash line (lower lash stays soft)

Radial strokes in iris from pupil outward; light sclera glaze; asymmetrical upper/lower lash treatment

Varies – Heavy on pupils, Light-Medium on iris and sclera, Heavy on upper lash line pressure

- The eye is the focal point and the lash line is the hardest edge in the portrait — this step anchors depth and focus. The upper lid casts a shadow, making the iris appear in a recess; the sclera is never pure white, and the pupil is a dark void before any light-reflection.
- First pass: Block in the pupil as pure PC935 Black, leaving a small specular highlight white (unpainted circle). Establish the cast shadow from the upper lid (a dark crescent above the iris) using PC1081 Chestnut slightly darkened with PC932 Violet. This creates the recess and makes the eye read as sitting back in the skull.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Layer PC903 True Blue in radial strokes FROM the pupil outward (like sun rays), varying pressure so the center is dense and the edge is lighter. Overlay PC920 Light Green (the measured light green) in the iris to add chromatic complexity and warm reflected light. The iris is NOT flat — the radial structure creates luminosity and depth.
- Third pass: Glaze PC1087 Sky Blue Light onto the sclera (not pure white), light pressure. Deepen the upper lid shadow with PC1081 Chestnut + PC932 Violet to create the hard lash line edge. The upper lash line is the SHARPEST edge in the eye zone; the lower lash stays soft and diffuse (never mirror).
- Fourth pass: Define the upper lash line with a single sharp dark stroke (PC935 Black, minimal pressure, single pass). Lower lash line stays lighter and diffuse — just a shadow-suggestion, not a hard edge. This asymmetry makes eyes read as naturally lit, not symmetrical.

COLORS

PC935 Black

PC1081 Chestnut

PC932 Violet

PC903 True Blue

PC920 Light Green

PC1086 Sky Blue Light

↔ If PC920 Light Green feels too pale for iris depth, layer PC903 True Blue more densely before the green overlay

STOP WHEN

Iris shows radial depth, sclera is lit (pale blue not pure white), upper lash is sharp and lower is soft · Radial strokes are visible and directional; no flat, filled iris

★ Students default to symmetrical eyes with equal lash lines. Nature rarely does this — the upper lid always casts shadow, the lower almost never casts an equal shadow. Breaking symmetry makes a portrait read as observed, not idealized. Also: the pupil is SMALL and dark; resist the urge to make it large and luminous — it's a void, not a light source.

05 Step 5: Lips & Mouth

Upper and lower lip, lip line (soft integration)

Directional side-to-side strokes following lip contour; warm overlay on lower lip; minimal fine creases

Light-Medium pressure

- Lips are where subsurface scattering is most visible (thin skin glows red-pink) and they sit at a natural value and temperature contrast. The upper lip is darker and cooler, the lower is lighter, warmer, more saturated — this asymmetry catches light naturally.
- First pass: Establish the upper lip in PC926 Carmine Red (cool red, measured as slightly deeper value). Directional strokes following the lip contour (side-to-side, not downward). This lip reads darker and cooler as it catches less direct light.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Layer PC928 Blush Pink onto the lower lip, slightly lighter pressure to preserve the warm glow and saturation. The lower lip catches light and should appear warmer and lighter than the upper. Overlay with PC939 Peach in the brightest (center) zone of the lower lip for peak warmth and luminosity.
- Third pass: Lip line stays soft and integrated — a faint PC1017 Clay Rose line (very light pressure) rather than a hard outline. Fine horizontal creases go in LAST with a sharp pencil at very light pressure (PC1081 Chestnut, single fine strokes), if visible in the reference. Do not overwork; a few creases suggest form, many read as damage.

COLORS



PC926 Carmine Red



PC928 Blush Pink



PC939 Peach



PC1017 Clay Rose



PC1081 Chestnut

↔ If PC926 Carmine Red feels too purple, use PC122 Permanent Red for a cleaner cool tone

STOP WHEN

Upper lip darker/cooler, lower lip lighter/warmer with a warm glow; lip line soft and integrated · Strokes follow form, no smearing or harsh edges

★ Lips are a temperature contrast zone — if you make both lips the same temperature and value, they flatten into the face. Keep the warm glow on the lower lip by reserving a bright warm stroke for the peak light. Also: lips in shadow are NOT purple or blue; they remain red-pink or mauve, just deeper.

06 Step 6: Hair – Loose Curly Structure (One Mass, Artist Ground Truth)

Loosecurlymass(crown,sides,shoulderregions),prioritizingstructurefirst,thenlight pattern

Curved strokes following the wrap of each coil, changing direction at turns; light pattern across the mass, not individual strands; sparse highlight placement

Light to Light-Medium pressure

- Artist ground truth specifies loose curly hair worn down on the shoulder(s). Curly hair is built with curved strokes following the wrap of each coil (never long downward strokes like straight hair), and the light pattern across the mass — not individual strands — creates luminosity. The root area is the darkest anchor.
- First pass: Begin at the crown and along the root-line with PC1081 Chestnut, using curved strokes that follow the direction each curl wraps (around the head, not downward). This establishes the darkest scaffold and form. Curves change direction wherever a section visibly turns or transitions — each clump has its own arc. Sparse initial placement; do not fill.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Layer PC945 Sienna Brown and PC1031 Henna in curved strokes following the same direction as the roots, building the mid-tone volume. Pressure slightly heavier than the base, but still light enough to preserve tooth. This pass unifies the curly mass and adds warmth.
- Third pass: Identify the light-struck areas (top of the crown, the outer curve of visible curls, shoulder-facing side if side-lit). Layer PC939 Peach and PC927 Light Peach into these zones with light, curved strokes, still following the coil direction. The light is NOT a solid fill — preserve dark spaces between clumps so the curls read as distinct forms, not one solid mass.
- Fourth pass: Reserve 1–2 pencil-light bright streaks (PC927 Light Peach, one light stroke per streak) along the outer curve of the most lit clump — this suggests shine without over-rendering. Deepen any visible shadow-side curl edges with PC1081 Chestnut + PC932 Violet if the reference shows them.

COLORS

 PC1081 Chestnut

 PC945 Sienna Brown

 PC1031 Henna

 PC939 Peach

 PC927 Light Peach

 PC932 Violet

↔ If PC945 Sienna Brown is unavailable, substitute PC944 Terra Cotta for warmth; if PC932 Violet for shadow edges feels too purple, use PC934 Lavender

STOP WHEN

Curly structure reads with volume and light pattern, light and dark zones distinct · Strokes curve with the coils, pressure allows next passes, paper tooth visible

★ The most common failure with curly hair: downward strokes instead of curved wraps. A downward stroke (the straight-hair habit) flattens a curl into a line — it reads as hair painted ON the skull, not growing FROM it. Curve every stroke around the form of the curl,

changing direction at the turn. If you see a flat patch instead of volume, you are stroking downward; switch to curves and the hair will pop.

07 Step 7: Neck – Form & Self-Shadow (Realistic Rendering, Artist-Requested)

Full visible neck(frontand sides),fromthe jaw-line down to the garmentedge

Vertical directional strokes along neck form; soft self-shadow with warm undertone; warm glow in center

Light to Light-Medium pressure

- The neck is a cylinder with a soft self-shadow on the underside where it recedes from the light. A visible self-shadow (not dark, but cooler mid-value) makes the neck read as three-dimensional rather than a flat connector.
- First pass: Establish the front/lit side of the neck using PC943 Burnt Ochre and PC1031 Henna at light-medium pressure, vertical strokes following the cylindrical form. Coverage across the entire visible neck, preserving form direction.
- Second pass (once the first is set): Layer PC1081 Chestnut at very light pressure in the immediate shadow zone under the jaw-line where the neck begins. This shadow is WARM (umber tones, not grey) and at mid-value, not dark. Directional strokes following the underside curve of the jaw and down the neck center. Blend gently into the lit plane.
- Third pass: Layer PC939 Peach in the center-front of the neck at very light pressure. This should be subtle but visible, warming the entire lit side and suggesting translucency.

COLORS



PC943 Burnt Ochre



PC1031 Henna



PC1081 Chestnut



PC939 Peach

↔ If PC939 Peach feels too saturated for neck glow, substitute PC927 Light Peach at very light pressure

STOP WHEN

Neck reads as a three-dimensional cylinder with visible self-shadow and form · Strokes follow the vertical form direction, shadow blends softly into lit plane

✦ A common error: making the neck shadow too dark or too cool (grey), which makes it look injured. The neck shadow is a WARM mid-value recess — it should read as shade, not damage. It should also NOT be as dark as the face core shadows; face shadows are deeper because of orbital and bone structure.

08 Step 8: Garment & Headband – Color & Bounce (Purple Headband & Neon Yellow-Green Tanktop)

Headband (across forehead/crown), tanktop (shoulders, chest, arms if visible), and the bounce zone (jawline, lower face, neck)

Directional strokes for garment fabric; horizontal for headband; layered optical mixing for neon yellow-green; light glaze strokes for bounce reflection

Medium for garment, Light for bounce pressure

- The purple headband and neon yellow-green tanktop reflect their hues onto adjacent skin (jaw, lower face, neck), creating a chromatic bounce. This bounce is critical optics — without it, the garment and face read as separate objects. The artist-supplied hue words are AUTHORITATIVE: purple (headband) and neon yellow-green (tanktop). First pass:
 - Establish the purple headband using PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue (measured #3d2955). Directional strokes following the band's direction (horizontal across the forehead/crown). Light-medium pressure with directional strokes, preserving slight texture.
 - Second pass (once the first is set): Build the tanktop in two layers for saturation: start with PC1035 Neon Yellow at medium pressure, directional strokes following the fabric direction. Overlay with PC920 Light Green in lighter zones to build the neon yellow-green hue. The saturation should read as bright and present. Garment shadows receive a slightly darker, cooler version: PC932 Violet under the neon to deepen without losing saturation.
 - Third pass: The purple headband casts violet/purple bounce light onto the upper face (forehead, above the eyebrows) — glaze PC934 Lavender at very light pressure onto these zones. The yellow-green tanktop casts neon yellow-green bounce onto the jawline, lower face, and neck — glaze PC1035 Neon Yellow at very light pressure onto these zones. The bounce is NOT opaque or heavy — it is a tint that says 'light is reflecting from that garment.' The neck especially should show warm yellow-green in the zones facing the tanktop.

COLORS



PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue



PC1035 Neon Yellow



PC920 Light Green



PC932 Violet



PC934 Lavender

↔ If PC1035 Neon Yellow is unavailable, layer PC1011 Deco Yellow + PC912 Apple Green to approach neon saturation

STOP WHEN

Garment color is bright and saturated, visible bounce appears on adjacent skin (purple tint on upper face, yellow-green tint on jaw/neck) · Garment strokes are directional (fabric-like), bounce strokes are light and integrated

★ Bounce light is the difference between 'figure floating on a painted background' and 'figure sitting in light.' Without the purple and yellow-green tints reflecting onto the jaw and

neck, the garment reads as a separate costume. A single glaze of the garment's hue, at very light pressure, is enough — students often over-render this and lose subtlety.

09 Step 9: Warm Glow & Transition Zones (Subsurface Scattering & Unification)

Cheeks (apples and sides), nose tip and bridge, ears (if visible), under-eye zone, transition between lit and shadow side

Very light circular glazing strokes; diffuse warmth fading outward; blending into surrounding tone

Light (very light, almost a whisper) pressure

- Skin glows warmest in the thinnest, most vascular zones: the cheeks, nose tip and bridge, ears, and the inner corner of the eyes. A warm glaze through these zones (not a local spot, but a diffuse wash) suggests living, breathing translucency and unifies skin tone across passes. This is the fastest way to make skin read as alive rather than plastic.

Single pass: Layer PC939 Peach across the cheekbones and nose at very light pressure,

- circular strokes, blending into surrounding areas. The glow should NOT be a blob or solid circle — it is a subtle warmth that suggests subsurface scattering, most intense at the peak of the cheekbone and the nose tip, fading outward. In the transition zone between lit and shadow side (the terminator), add a thin glaze of PC1017 Clay Rose to keep the edge warm and prevent a cool, ashy appearance. Light pressure throughout — this glaze unifies, it does not define. The entire pass should read as a gentle warmth, not a visible layer.

COLORS



PC939 Peach



PC1017 Clay Rose

↔ If PC939 Peach feels too saturated, substitute PC927 Light Peach for a subtler glow

STOP WHEN

Skin reads as warm and luminous across all tones, transition zone glows · Glazes are light and diffuse, no visible strokes, smooth blending, paper tooth barely visible

✦ Subsurface scattering is the fastest way to make skin read as alive. If your face looks plastic or painted, it is usually because the subsurface warmth is missing or too subtle. Err on the side of TOO MUCH warm glow early — it is easier to tone down than to resurrect.

10 Step 10: Edge Refinement & Focus Control

Entire figure outline—lashline (sharpest), face planes to hair (soften), jaw to neck (soft), neck to garment (integrate), garment to background (lose)

Sharp directional darks for lash line; light circular blending strokes for edges softening; directional strokes for transitions

Medium for sharpening, Light for softening pressure

- Hard edges advance and grab the eye; soft and lost edges recede. Edge hierarchy (sharpest at the focal point, soft outward) guides the viewer's eye and creates focus. The lash line is the sharpest edge; hair, jaw, and garment soften into the background or shadow. This step is where a portrait suddenly organizes around a focal point.
- Sharpen the upper lash line by deepening with PC1081 Chestnut + PC932 Violet where it meets the shadow, creating a crisp boundary between eye and lid. Make this edge HARD — it is the focal point.
- Soften the jaw-line by blending PC945 Sienna Brown or PC943 Burnt Ochre along the edge, allowing it to dissolve into shadow rather than read as a hard contour. Pressure should be light and circular, diffusing the edge.
- Hair-to-face boundary: where hair meets the forehead or cheek, allow the edge to become diffuse — use light pressure and blended strokes rather than a drawn line.
- Garment-to-neck transition: ensure the neckline and garment edge blend smoothly into the neck skin via the bounce-light glaze (the yellow-green tint carries the eye from garment to skin, softening the hard boundary).
- Garment-to-background: if the background is visible, soften the garment's outer edge by allowing it to fade rather than read as a cutout.

COLORS



PC1081 Chestnut



PC932 Violet



PC945 Sienna Brown



PC943 Burnt Ochre

↔ If PC945 Sienna Brown is unavailable, use PC943 Burnt Ochre for all jaw softening

STOP WHEN

Lash line is the sharpest edge, all other edges softer and more integrated · Blending strokes are smooth and directional, no harsh lines except at the focal point (eye)

✦ Edge hierarchy solves focus in colored pencil faster than value or color — sharpness IS attention. If every edge is sharp, no edge reads as sharp. Reserve your hardest work for the eye and lash line, soften everything else, and watch the portrait suddenly organize around a focal point.

11 Step 11: Final Highlights & Burnish (Peak Highlights, Wax Bloom Correction)

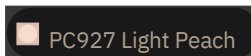
Forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks (where light hits directly), dark anchor re-establishment (pupils, eye socket, jaw core shadow)

Precise strike highlights; heavy-pressure burnishing with light pencil; light-pressure re-darks; optional cloth wipe

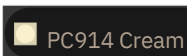
Heavy for burnishing and peak highlights, Medium-Heavy for dark re-establishment pressure

- Burnishing melts the layers into a painted finish, but wax bloom migrates up and lightens values — the deepest darks must be re-established after. Peak highlights are the LAST thing applied, struck with a hard value jump. This final pass shifts the portrait from 'drawing' to 'painting.'
- First pass – Peak Highlights: Strike the forehead apex with PC927 Light Peach, heavy pressure, a single small precise stroke. Nose bridge and tip: PC927 Light Peach with a hard edge where the highlight boundary is crisp. Cheekbone peak: PC927 Light Peach, a small deliberate stroke along the highest plane. These highlights are tiny and intentional, not smudged — they are the brightest points of the portrait.
- Second pass – Burnishing (Wax Melt & Bloom Rise): Using PC914 Cream pencil at heavy pressure, go over the entire face, melting layers into a smooth, painted finish. This eliminates paper texture and white flecks, but it LIGHTENS values as wax rises. Do not burnish aggressively; firm pressure is enough.
- Third pass – Dark Anchor Re-establishment (REQUIRED, NOT OPTIONAL): After burnishing, re-establish the deepest darks that may have lightened: pupils (PC935 Black, heavy pressure), upper lash line (PC1081 Chestnut + PC932 Violet, medium-heavy), eye socket core (PC947 Dark Umber, medium), jaw-line recess (PC1081 Chestnut, medium). These darks are NOT re-covering the whole shadow — just punching back the core darks that bloom lifted. Do NOT burnish over these re-darkenings.
- Fourth pass – Wax Bloom Removal (Optional but recommended): Once the re-darks are set, gently wipe the face with a soft cloth or very light artist's fixative to remove any hazy wax bloom on the surface. This restores some brightness to the midtones and makes the portrait read crisp rather than cloudy.

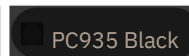
COLORS



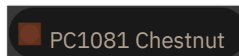
PC927 Light Peach



PC914 Cream



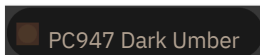
PC935 Black



PC1081 Chestnut



PC932 Violet



PC947 Dark Umber

↔ If PC927 Light Peach is unavailable, substitute PC939 Peach for highlights (slightly less bright but still warm)

STOP WHEN

Peak highlights are struck, wax bloom is minimal, darks are re-established and read true · Burnishing is complete, no texture or white flecks visible prior to dark re-establishment; darks remain sharp and luminous after

✦ Burnishing is the moment students most often lose their drawing. A too-aggressive burnish darkens and muddies everything. Burnish with a LIGHT pencil and FIRM pressure (not aggressive), aiming for a subtle melt. Then, ALWAYS re-darken — it is not optional. The bloom lift is real, and if you do not punch the darks back, the portrait reads as washed-out. Finally: the peak highlights are the very last marks — strike them once and leave them.

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.